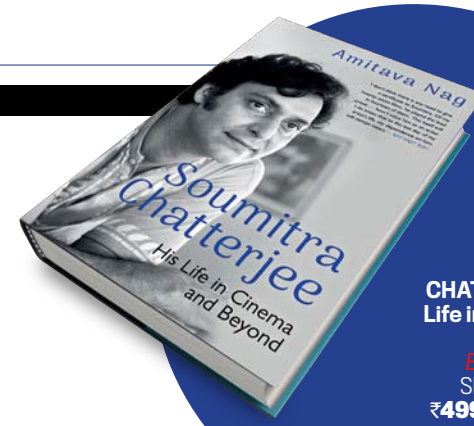
BOOKS

# The Greatest Showman

A biography of **Soumitra Chatterjee** by Amitava Nag sheds light on professional and personal aspects of the late actor's life




**SOUMITRA CHATTERJEE: His Life in Cinema and Beyond**
*By Amitava Nag*
SPEAKING TIGER
**₹499; 240** pages

**THE YEAR WAS 2010**. The newsmagazine I worked for was doing a cover story on celebrated actors, who, accustomed to always being in front of the camera, would go behind it for a change and click a photo that would symbolise for them the idea of life. I asked Soumitra Da who, ever gracious, obliged. This time, he was also gleeful. The idea had really appealed to him. "For me, it is a stretch of the Hooghly River," he said, smiling his signature, almost-shy smile, "particularly that part of it which flows below the Howrah Bridge, undeterred by the congestion above". In the car, as we drove towards the riverbank for the photo shoot, he explained, "I think flowing rivers represent life, sometimes turbulent, sometimes triumphant, as they overcome the trials and tribulations along the way. But they never stop until they reach their destinations and then finally disappear into the vast (unknown)." Ten years later, we lost Soumitra Da to the vast unknown.

But he has left behind an incredible legacy. This posthumous biography by Amitava Nag gives us a glimpse into the life of the renowned thespian and polymath, and of the trials and tribulations and, of course, the triumphs that it traversed.

Nag's book is an insider's account. A film critic based in Kolkata, he had interviewed Chatterjee many times, but gradually, their association became much more than a professional one and the duo spent days and hours conversing. "I seldom missed the opportunity to spend time with him. In those meetings, we spoke about...love, life, longing and regrets. We spoke about separation and desire... We shared information on books... films...poetry." Nag adds that the discussions were informal. "There were no recorders that invaded our privacy and made him conscious and reserved."

**NAG'S BOOK IS AN INSIDER'S ACCOUNT, BUT IT'S ALSO BASED ON A FAIR AMOUNT OF RESEARCH AND INTERVIEWS**

The narrative is based largely on these conversations, but also, as is apparent, on a fair amount of research and other interviews—there are quotes from Chatterjee's friends, family and fans, not to mention his directors and fellow actors. Sprinkled with the author's own analysis and insights, the book delves into the mind of the man who was famously known as Satyajit Ray's protégé and the "thinking person's" Bengali hero. Nag takes us on a fascinating journey, flashbacking to Chatterjee's childhood in the pre-Independence Nadia district in Bengal, which was divided during the Partition.

Nag looks into practically every phase of Chatterjee's professional and even personal life (marriage, children), analysing decisions and actions like why he decided never to leave Bengal for the lure of lucre or why he had an image makeover. The book is a comprehensive account of a lifetime spanning 85 years. The added attraction are the rare photographs, depicting Chatterjee at various stages of his life and with friends, family, directors and others, drawn from private collections and albums. The author, however, issues a caveat: don't look for "gossip" or "juicy tales". ■

***Dola Mitra***

## NORTHEAST RISING

**Ashish Kundra's** book is an incisive look at how India's northeast is rapidly integrating with the mainstream

For anyone interested in knowing about India's northeast, a region with a growing presence in the mind space of the "national mainstream", Ashish Kundra's *A Resurgent Northeast: Narratives of Change*, can act as a primer. The author is an IAS officer from the AGMUT (Arunachal Pradesh-Goa-Mizoram and Union Territory) cadre and served in Arunachal Pradesh and Mizoram. Through his job, he had substantial exposure to the region. Fortunately, the book doesn't read like a bureaucratic report, but like a long-form journalistic piece with an outsider's perspective.




**A RESURGENT NORTHEAST**
**Narratives of Change**
*By Ashish Kundra*
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
**₹399; 236** pages

The book begins by trying to understand the roots of backwardness in the northeast. Without directly blaming India's first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru, as has been the norm these days, Kundra hints at Nehru's well-intentioned policy of protecting tribal culture in the region by isolating it from over-administration. There are other factors, too, such as insurgency, corruption and Delhi's obsession with security, which led to a chasm between the northeast and the mainstream.

But the past several years have seen an upsurge, which the author has rightly credited to the aspirations of the new generations. Of course, the eight states